HACKTOBERFEST 2026 · OSCA ILE-IFE

OPEN//BUILD

2026

AI belongs to everyone.

OSCA Ile-Ife Hacktoberfest Challenge
Build for a world you understand. Make it open.

₦150,000	5 days	2	7
Total prize pool	Oct 25 – 29, 2026	Students per team	Teams at Demo Day

KEY DATES · ALL TIMES WAT

- **Oct 25 – 29** — Challenge window — Five days to build your prototype
- **Thu, Oct 29 · 11:59 PM** — Submission deadline — Repository and demo links must work
- **Sat, Oct 31 · 9:00 AM** — Top seven announced — Notified through the OSCA community
- **Sat, Oct 31 · 4:00 PM** — Virtual Demo Day — 3 min slides + 5 min live demo

Open Source Community Africa (OSCA), Ile-Ife

1 About the Challenge

OPEN//BUILD is an AI-focused building challenge organised by Open Source Community Africa (OSCA), Ile-Ife, as part of its Hacktoberfest 2026 programme.

The challenge invites university students to explore the possibilities of open-source AI by building practical solutions to problems they understand. Participants work in pairs to develop a functional prototype using an open-weight model, document their work, and publish their projects on GitHub.

The goal is to move beyond experimenting with AI tools and begin building, testing, documenting, and sharing solutions that other people can learn from and improve.

> **New to AI products?** You do not need to have built one before. You need a clear problem, a willingness to learn, and the commitment to build something that works within five days.

2 The Challenge

Build for a world you understand.

Your mission is to build a working prototype of an AI-powered solution to a problem you understand, using an open-weight model. Start with a problem that matters to you or to a group of people you understand. Identify who experiences the problem, explore how AI could help, and build a prototype that demonstrates your proposed solution.

Your project should do more than include an AI model for the sake of it. The model should play a meaningful role in solving the problem. You are encouraged to explore education, healthcare, accessibility, productivity, research, local information, language technology, agriculture, or any other area where you can identify a clear need.

The challenge is not about building the biggest product. It is about understanding a problem, making thoughtful technical decisions, and showing what your solution can do.

3 Eligibility and Team Formation

Eligibility
Open exclusively to currently enrolled university students.

Team size
Exactly two members. Solo submissions and teams of more than two are not permitted.

Cross-university teams
You may team up with a student from a different university.

One team per participant
Each participant may belong to only one team for the duration of the challenge.

Organisers may request proof of current university enrolment. Both team members should contribute meaningfully to the project and understand the work being submitted.

4 What You Can Build

You have the freedom to choose your problem and solution, provided the project meets the challenge requirements.

Education
An AI study assistant that explains difficult concepts or supports learning in a specific subject.

Healthcare
Helps users understand or organise health information, or explore a research problem. Must communicate limitations and never present an unvalidated prototype as clinically reliable.

Language and accessibility
A tool that supports local languages, improves access to information, or assists people with specific communication needs.

Productivity
An assistant that helps users organise information, complete repetitive tasks, or make sense of documents.

Research
A tool that supports literature exploration, data analysis, scientific experimentation, or another research workflow.

Local information
An application that makes useful information easier to access, search, understand, or use.

Creative applications
A tool that uses an open-weight model to support a creative or technical workflow.

Your own idea
These are examples, not approved categories. Propose a different idea if it meets the requirements.

5 Technical Requirements

Every submitted project must satisfy all five of the following.

A **Solve a defined problem**
Identify a specific problem and its intended users. Explain why the problem matters and how your solution addresses it.

B **Use an open-weight model meaningfully**
The model must be a meaningful part of the functionality. Explain which model you selected, what it does, and why it suits the task. Explore repositories such as Hugging Face, subject to availability and licence. **Open weights do not automatically mean fully open source.** You must check and comply with the model's licence and usage restrictions.

C **Build a working prototype**
Demonstrate the core functionality. A polished interface is not a substitute for a working solution. A web app, mobile app, CLI tool, API, or research prototype are all fine.

D **Publish on GitHub**
A repository accessible to the judges, with a README explaining the project and how to run, test, or reproduce it.

E **Explain your technical decisions**
Document the model used, how it fits your solution, important dependencies, known limitations, and significant implementation decisions.

6 What You May Use

You do not have to build everything from scratch. You may use existing libraries, frameworks, APIs, public datasets, model repositories, starter templates, and other legitimate development resources, provided you comply with their licences and acknowledge significant reused work.

You may also use AI coding assistants and other development tools. However, you must understand the work you submit, be able to explain your implementation, and disclose significant AI-assisted contributions where relevant.

Keep secrets secret
Do not expose API keys, passwords, credentials, private information, or sensitive personal data in your repository or demonstration.

Not permitted
Plagiarism, impersonation, fabricated results, and misrepresentation of contributions or project capabilities.

7 Five-Day Building Plan

October 25 – 29, 2026. A suggested workflow; teams may organise differently as long as they meet the deadline.

Day 1 Oct 25	**Define the problem** Identify your intended users, describe the problem, choose a model, and decide what your prototype must demonstrate. Keep the initial scope manageable.
Day 2 Oct 26	**Experiment with the model** Test the model on your intended task. Explore its strengths and limitations, and confirm it can support the functionality you want.
Day 3 Oct 27	**Build the core feature** Implement the main functionality and connect the model to your application or workflow. Prioritise the feature that demonstrates your solution's value.
Day 4 Oct 28	**Test and document** Test the prototype, fix important issues, prepare the README, document setup instructions, and explain the model and its limitations.
Day 5 Oct 29	**Finalise and submit** Check that the project works, confirm the repository is accessible, prepare your demonstration, and submit before 11:59 PM WAT.

8 Submission Requirements

Submit by 11:59 PM WAT, Thursday, October 29, 2026. The official form will be shared through the OSCA Ile-Ife community.

Project name	The name of your solution.
Team details	Full names of both team members and their universities.
Problem statement	The problem you are addressing and the people affected by it.
Solution description	What your project does and how it addresses the problem.
GitHub repository	A link to the repository, accessible to the judges.
Working demonstration	A live demo link, demo video, or clear instructions for running the prototype.
Model information	The model used, its role, why it was selected, and relevant limitations.
Documentation	A README with setup or reproduction instructions, dependencies, and other information needed to understand the project.
Acknowledgements	Licences, datasets, reused code, external resources, and significant AI-assisted work.

Test your repository and demo links before submitting. Late submissions may be excluded from judging.

9 Judging Criteria

100-point rubric. A large project does not automatically score higher than a small one: judges weigh understanding, effectiveness, and documentation.

CRITERION	POINTS
Problem understanding and usefulness Clarity of the problem, understanding of intended users, and usefulness of the proposed solution.	25
Working prototype and technical execution Whether the core functionality works and how effectively the team implements its solution.	25
Meaningful use of an open-weight model How the model contributes to the solution and the thoughtfulness of the team's model choices.	20
Creativity and thoughtful design Originality of the approach, quality of the user experience, and suitability of the design.	15
Open-source practices and documentation Repository quality, README, licensing, acknowledgements, and reproducibility.	15
Total	**100**

10 Prizes

Total prize pool: ₦150,000

MAIN PRIZES · ₦100,000

1ST PLACE	2ND PLACE	3RD PLACE
₦50,000	**₦30,000**	**₦20,000**

SPECIAL AWARDS · ₦50,000

BEST OPEN-SOURCE PRACTICE	MOST CREATIVE SOLUTION	COMMUNITY IMPACT AWARD
₦20,000	**₦15,000**	**₦15,000**

Special awards recognise teams outside the overall top three. The organisers will communicate any further award conditions before judging.

11 Top Seven Teams and Virtual Demo Day

After the deadline, judges review entries and select the top seven teams to present at the virtual Demo Day.

Top seven notification	Virtual Demo Day	Format
Sat, Oct 31, 2026 · by 9:00 AM WAT	Sat, Oct 31, 2026 · 4:00 PM WAT	Virtual presentation and live demo

3 min	5 min	8 min
Present your slides	Live prototype demo	Total slot per team

What your presentation should cover

1. The problem
Who experiences it, and why it matters.

2. The intended users
Who uses it, and in what situation.

3. Your solution
What you built and what makes it distinctive.

4. The AI model
Which model, why, and its limitations.

5. The working prototype
What is implemented and what judges will see.

6. Technical decisions
Tools, architecture, and challenges.

7. Open-source practices
How others can run, reproduce, or contribute.

8. Potential and next steps
Who benefits, adoption, what you'd improve.

Tip: you do not need a slide for every point. Prioritise the essentials for the three-minute slot and let the demo do the talking. Judges may include product managers, AI engineers, open-source advocates, and founders. The meeting link and arrangements will be shared with selected teams via the OSCA Ile-Ife community.

12 Communication and Updates

Join the official **OSCA Ile-Ife WhatsApp community** for challenge announcements, submission instructions, reminders, and Demo Day updates. Teams are responsible for checking announcements and meeting the stated deadlines.

Join the community: chat.whatsapp.com/DOT66pktajn3rZlpULwFlW

13 Code of Conduct and General Conditions

By participating, you agree to the following:

- Your team must meet the eligibility and team-size requirements.
- You must submit work that your team has contributed to and can explain.
- You must acknowledge significant external resources, reused code, datasets, and AI-assisted work.
- You must comply with the licences and usage restrictions of models, datasets, libraries, and other resources.
- You must not plagiarise, impersonate another participant, fabricate results, or misrepresent what your project can do.
- You must not publish secrets, credentials, private information, or sensitive personal data.
- Your repository must remain accessible to the judges during evaluation.
- You must meet the submission deadline and follow the Demo Day instructions if selected.
- Organisers reserve the right to disqualify submissions that violate the challenge rules. The judges' decisions are final.

14 · YOUR STARTING POINT

Build for a world you understand. Make it open.

Five days, a teammate, and a growing ecosystem of open-weight models. Show a clear idea and a prototype that works.